



◀ BAGHDAD, MARCH 2003

This apocalyptic image shows Baghdad burning during the opening stages of the coalition assault. US electronic counter-measures suppressed Iraqi air-defences, leaving the city fatally vulnerable to attack.

KEY EVENTS

20TH–21ST CENTURY

■ **September 1943** An air-launched radio-controlled German bomb ("Fritz-X") hits the Italian battleship *Roma*. This is the first use of a guided weapon in combat.

■ **April–May 1972** US aircraft destroy the Thanh Hoa bridge in North Vietnam with laser-guided bombs; the bridge had survived 800 previous US sorties using conventional bombs.

■ **1960s** The first night-vision devices are used, by US troops in the Vietnam conflict.

■ **1991** Operation Desert Storm sees the first mass use of precision-guided munitions against military targets in Iraq, including laser-guided bombs (LGBs).

■ **July 1995** The US Predator UAV enters service, and is seen by some military theorists as the future of air warfare in the 21st century.

■ **2000s** Panoramic Night Vision Goggles (PNVGs) are developed and assigned to selected US aircrews, providing 95-degree vision.

longer brings military operations to a halt. Night-vision equipment was initially based on heavy, infra-red scopes, but improvements, including the arrival of light-intensifying starlight scopes, have made the 24-hour battlefield a reality.

The 1991 Gulf War proved the value of these, when a US-led force using the latest battlefield technology succeeded in ejecting the army of Iraqi dictator Saddam Hussein from Kuwait with little difficulty. The importance of the US and coalition

forces' advanced weapons was confirmed a few years later in the success of the well-coordinated 2003 invasion of Iraq, against a much less well-equipped Iraqi army. This mastery has given the armed forces of advanced nations – especially the US – a significant advantage over the less well-equipped conventional armies of other nations.

However, terrorists armed with the simplest weapons have still been able to wreak havoc in Western societies, for example in the attacks on the US in 2001. In Iraq, insurgent groups emerged from the ruins to wage a sustained war against occupying forces, and in Afghanistan, the materially superior US and its allies have been unable to defeat Taliban fighters. The latter use classic guerrilla tactics – striking at weak points before melting back into the civilian population, or using civilians as human shields during firefights. For all their advanced technology, the armies of the West have yet to overcome simply-armed, determined insurgents, some of whom would rather face death than be defeated.



◀ RAPIER SURFACE-TO-AIR MISSILE LAUNCHER

The Rapier is noted for its accuracy and fast reaction time; it is used for ground-to-air defence by nine countries, including Switzerland, Turkey, and Iran. A mobile, tracked version is also in service.

“Our troops will have the best possible support in the entire world, and they will not be asked to fight with one hand tied behind their back”

US PRESIDENT GEORGE BUSH SR., 1991

